It Really Happened

# A Thought on Parashat Vayera

Dvar Torah - a printable page



In Parashat Vayera, the Torah tells us about the destruction of Sodom and Amorah. The people of Sodom and Amorah were very wicked, and Hashem had to punish them and turn their cities into a wasteland. After Hashem tells Avraham that Sodom will be destroyed, Avraham Avinu asks Hashem to have mercy on the whole city if fifty righteous people can be found there. After Hashem agrees to his request, Avraham Avinu goes on to ask for forty-five righteous people too. From there Avraham goes down to forty, and so on, until he reaches just ten righteous people.

But we can ask: why does Avraham Avinu need to start with fifty righteous people? Why doesn't he ask Hashem from the very beginning to have mercy on the whole city for the sake of just ten?

The answer is that Avraham Avinu is teaching us how to reach things that seem impossible to us. When Avraham asks Hashem to have mercy on the whole city for the sake of ten righteous people, he has to believe that it's possible - because if he himself doesn't believe it's possible, Hashem won't agree to it either. So he starts by asking for fifty righteous people, something that already seems beyond reason. After Hashem agrees to his request, Avraham's faith grows stronger, and it becomes easier for him to reach further - to ask for forty-five righteous people, for forty, and so on. Little by little, Avraham Avinu keeps going down, until he reaches ten.

Avraham Avinu teaches us that to go far, we need to keep at it, step by step, until the thing we're reaching for becomes possible in our own minds too. Only then can we pray for it properly and come closer to making the dream come true.

**Shabbat Shalom, and a blessed one!**